



Cup underscored the team's newfound resilience. Desai's formula is simple. "We are trying to have the identity of being the fiercest competitors. When you are competing well in every department, then, more often than not, you have the opportunity to cross the line. That's how we have tried to stay on this journey."

Desai enlisted former Maharashtra cricketer Nandan Phadnis as the batting coach and persuaded the association to host teams from Ireland and the West Indies in Nepal.

When planning the India tour, Desai prioritised finding a residential facility conducive to focused training. "We sought venues that fit our needs, leading us to choose this facility in Vapi."

Operated by local sports enthusiasts Darpan Desai, Manish Bambania, Mehul Trivedi, Santosh Singh, Sukesh, and Suraj Shetty, the Sai Meghpan facility boasts lush green grounds, state-of-the-art training facilities, a gym, and accommodation. Paudel sees the

merits clearly. "These camps help us bond well. Staying together for a couple of weeks, and just discussing the game and helping each other out will not only bring the players closer but also help us plan better for the upcoming assignments."

The Nepal players plan on reaching the US by mid-May. While the conditions will pose challenges and the opponents will be formidable, Nepal enters the fray armed with self-belief, ready to prove it is no pushover. Paudel has been leading by example against West Indies A with a century and a couple of fifty-plus scores. Meanwhile, Airee, fresh from his remarkable achievement of equalling a world record by smashing six sixes in an over against Qatar in April, promises to be a vital cog in the team's batting lineup.

But all eyes will be on young sensation Gulshan Jha, who recently featured in the U-19 World Cup. Jha's journey to this point has been nothing short of remarkable. Six years ago, he embarked on a journey to Ranchi to pursue his passion for

Gearing up: Nepal pacer K.C. Karan warming up for the upcoming T20 World Cup at the Sai Meghpan Sportslife Cricket Ground in Vapi, Gujarat. EMMANUAL YOGINI

cricket under the mentorship of former cricketer Arun Vidyarthi. "I was decent in studies, but cricket has always been my first love. Luckily, my parents supported my dream and sent me to Ranchi, where I lived in a hostel and pursued the game," shared Jha, a versatile pacer with skills in batting down the order.

Growing up in Sarlahi, Gulshan heard inspiring stories of how Khadka and his team overcame the odds to play their maiden T20 World Cup in 2014. "Those stories inspired me, and I am lucky to be representing my country in another T20 World Cup," Jha said with a smile.

A decade later, Nepal's cricketers are poised for another milestone, aiming to shine in the US and make their nation proud. It's been quite a journey, but the dream chasers are in no mood to stop.